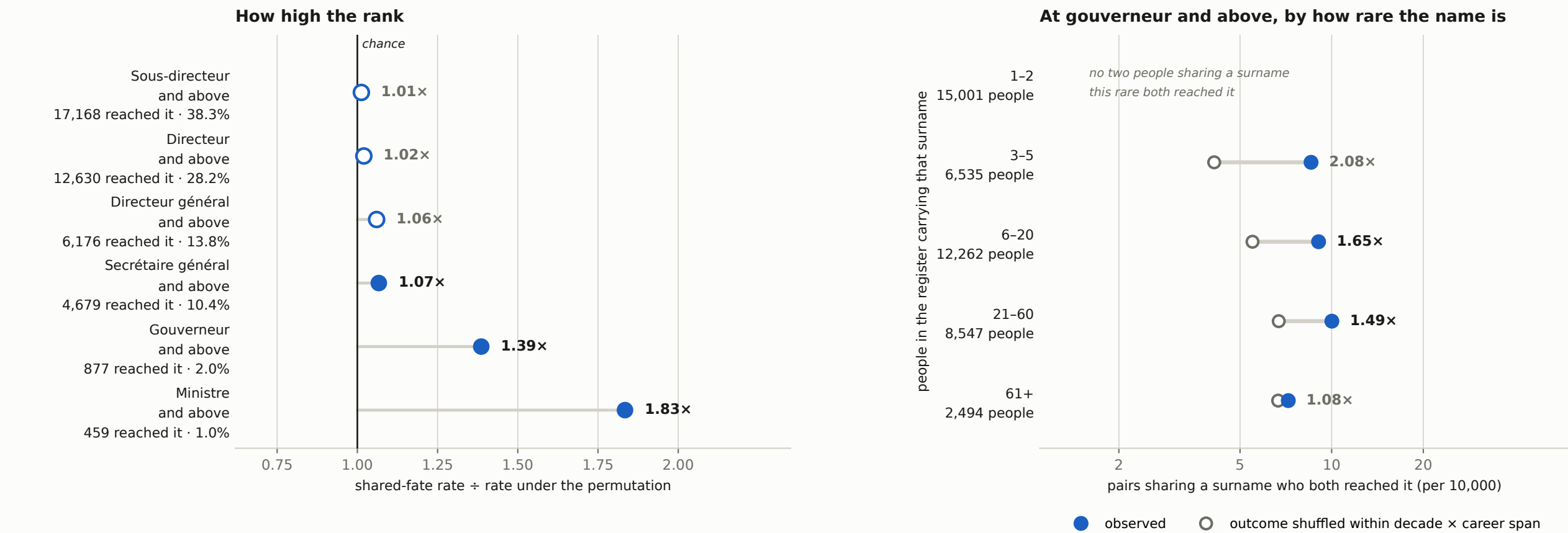


A surname says little about becoming a director and a good deal about becoming a minister

Left: how much more often two people sharing a surname both reach a rank than when the outcome is shuffled among people of the same entry decade and career span. The effect climbs the scale — 1.01× at sous-directeur and above, where 38% of the register arrives, and 1.83× at ministre and above, where 1.0% does. Right: the same statistic at gouverneur and above, split by how many people carry the surname. It runs from 2.08× for a name held by 3–5 people down to 1.08× for one held by more than sixty — the direction kinship predicts, since a rare name shared is evidence of a family and a common one shared is mostly not.



Source: Journal Officiel de la République Tunisienne, 1957–2026 (6,378 French issues, jort.tn). Author's extraction. Rank is the highest position a person is recorded holding, on the ordinal scale the codebook sets out. The null shuffles who reached the rank within strata of entry decade and career span, leaving surname groups untouched; both controls are needed, because the rate of reaching directeur général and above runs from 5% for someone recorded in a single year to 44% for someone whose career spans twenty-one or more, and from 21% for the 1980s cohort to 7% for the 2020s. Shuffling surnames instead gives the same headline (1.06×, 1.40×, 1.82× against 1.06×, 1.38×, 1.86×) but cannot be split by rarity, because the split is defined on a person's own surname while the permutation gives them another. A filled marker means fewer than 5% of permutations reached the observed value. The top of the scale is thin and the reader should hold it lightly: at ministre and above, 459 people carry 381 distinct surnames, of which 54 are held by two or more, giving 114 pairs; the largest such group is six people. The surname proxy has the same two defects fig33 sets out — 77% of people recorded under several spellings disagree with themselves, and the commonest surnames here are the commonest in Tunisia — and both push these ratios towards chance, so they are floors. A transmission design, asking whether a person whose namesake had already reached high rank was likelier to get there, is not drawn: having such a precedent is nearly the same fact as entering late (2007 on average against 1985 for those without), so the comparison is confounded by construction rather than by anything stratification can remove. No ranking of surnames is computed anywhere in this build.